Figure Out What to Do First When Everything About Your Husband's Care Is Urgent

Four prompts to separate the decisions from the chores, find the one decision with a real date, list what has to be known before you make it, and see how much of the work is sitting on one person.

Where you are

Your husband's discharge is set, the rehab wants an answer about what happens after, the pharmacy has questions, and your daughter has a list of things she thinks you should have done yesterday. Everything feels like it has to happen today.

This guide gives you four ChatGPT prompts to organize what you already know and to see what you don't know yet. It is preparation, not an assessment. Use only information you have permission to share, with names removed. The AI organizes and drafts; it does not diagnose, assess safety, or decide. Bring clinical questions to a clinician, and call emergency services for an emergency.

What you'll have at the end

You can say which decision is actually next and when it's due, what you need to know before making it, and which tasks you're going to hand to someone else.

A one-page list with three headings: The Next Decision and When, What Must Be Settled First, and Work to Share Out.

Before you start

- Every decision and task you can think of, dumped into one list, in any order.
- Any dates you've actually been given, with who gave them.
- A rough idea of who in the family has offered to help, and with what. If the list is a mess, that's what the first prompt is for.

PROMPT 1

Dump everything and sort it

WHY THIS MATTERS

When it all feels urgent, the first relief is seeing that half the pile is chores and a third is questions. Only a few items are decisions, and those are the ones that need you.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

Your whole list, unsorted, and any dates you've been given.

COPY THIS PROMPT

> Everything about my husband's care feels urgent, so here is the whole pile, in no order:
>
> [PASTE YOUR LIST]

> Sort it into three lists: DECISIONS, meaning choices we have to make; TASKS, meaning things someone has to do; and QUESTIONS, meaning things we have to find out. Keep every item; don't merge or drop anything. Next to each item, write DATE GIVEN if I've mentioned a real deadline and who gave it, or NO DATE if I haven't. Don't add any deadlines of your own, and don't tell me yet what to do first.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

A DECISIONS list that is shorter than you feared.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

Read the DECISIONS list out loud to one other person and see if they'd add anything.

PROMPT 2

Find the one decision that's really next

WHY THIS MATTERS

Urgency comes from a date. Most of the dates in your head were never given to you by anyone; they're guesses the family has started treating as deadlines.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

The DECISIONS list from the first prompt.

COPY THIS PROMPT

> Here are the decisions about my husband's care and the dates I've been given:
>
> [PASTE THE DECISIONS LIST FROM PROMPT 1]
>
> Tell me which decision has the nearest confirmed date. Then put the decisions in order by date, and for each one, say whether another decision on the list has to be made first. Mark each date CONFIRMED if I told you who gave it, and ASSUMED if it's something the family has guessed. Where there is no date, write NO DATE GIVEN rather than inventing one. Finish with one sentence naming what you'd call the next decision and why.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

How many dates are ASSUMED. Those can often be checked with one call.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

Confirm the nearest date with whoever set it, and write down their name.

PROMPT 3

List what has to be settled first

WHY THIS MATTERS

Acting before the groundwork is done is how families end up redoing things. The next decision depends on a few facts, and some of them belong to a doctor, a pharmacist, or a social worker, not to you.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

The next decision from the second prompt, and the QUESTIONS list from the first.

COPY THIS PROMPT

> The next decision about my husband's care is: [THE DECISION FROM PROMPT 2]. Here is what I know and the questions still open:
>
> [PASTE THE QUESTIONS LIST AND ANY NOTES]
>
> List everything this decision depends on, one item per line. Mark each SETTLED, OPEN, or DON'T KNOW. For every OPEN or DON'T KNOW item, write who could settle it: family, his doctor or nurse, a pharmacist, the social worker, a care consultant, or not sure. Don't answer the medical, legal, or money questions yourself; just list them with the right person beside them. Tell me which items can be settled with one phone call.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

The OPEN items that belong to a professional. Those are the calls to make first.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

Make the one-phone-call items today, and note what each person said.

PROMPT 4

See who's carrying the load, then put it on one page

WHY THIS MATTERS

If your name is next to most of the tasks, the plan won't survive the first bad week. This page makes the load visible and gives you a list to hand out.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

Everything from the first three prompts, with a note on who is currently doing each task.

COPY THIS PROMPT

> Here is everything I've sorted about my husband's care:
>
> [PASTE THE RESULTS OF PROMPTS 1 TO 3, WITH WHO IS CURRENTLY DOING EACH TASK]
>
> First, count how many tasks sit with each person and tell me if most of them are on one name. Then give me one page with three headings: THE NEXT DECISION AND WHEN, WHAT MUST BE SETTLED FIRST, and WORK TO SHARE OUT. Under the last heading, list tasks I could hand off and what kind of person could take each: a relative, a friend, a paid helper, or a professional. Don't assign anything to a named person, and don't decide the care arrangement itself.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

A WORK TO SHARE OUT list you'd be willing to read to your daughter.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

Keep the page and go to the next step below. It's where the whole picture gets built.

Build the sequence on the whole picture

You've sorted the next few weeks. The care interview records your husband's full situation in a Family Care Profile, so the order you decide things in rests on everything, not just what's loudest this week. It's the file a professional will use to help you sequence what follows.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›